Workforce Practices: Facilitator Guide

Business Academy Group Learning · Workforce Practices · August 2027

Session at a glance

In 60 minutes, providers strengthen how they hire, onboard, support, and keep staff, with a focus on low-cost practices that improve retention. Home-based providers focus on their own professional growth and any assistants or substitutes.

Item	Detail
Month	August 2027
Audience	Business Academy providers, center-based and home-based
Length	60 minutes
Format	[In person / virtual]
Materials	Sample job description, onboarding checklist, sample staff check-in questions, printed Tips and Tricks sheet and Provider Handout
Ask providers to bring	Current job descriptions or staff handbook if they have them

Learning goals

By the end, each provider can:

1. Write or improve a clear job description.
2. Use an onboarding checklist for new staff.
3. Plan regular check-ins and professional development.
4. Choose one practice to improve staff retention.

Agenda

Time	Segment
0:00 – 0:05	Welcome and opener: “My best first day on a job”
0:05 – 0:15	Why workforce practices matter: retention, quality, and cost
0:15 – 0:30	Hiring, onboarding, support, and growth
0:30 – 0:45	Activity: Build your onboarding checklist
0:45 – 0:55	Implementation: your 30-day plan and one commitment
0:55 – 1:00	Takeaways and wrap-up

Why workforce practices matter

Opener, “My best first day on a job”: Ask providers what made a first day at any job feel welcoming. Connect answers to what new staff need in their program.

Talking points:

- **Good practices keep good people.** Staff who feel prepared and supported are more likely to stay.

- **Turnover is costly.** As covered in March, replacing a teacher costs time and money.
- **The first weeks matter most.** A strong onboarding helps new staff succeed quickly.
- **Growth keeps people engaged.** Training and a path forward show staff they have a future here.
- **Small programs count too.** Assistants, substitutes, and the owner all benefit from clear practices.

Core content: the staff life cycle

Stage	Practices that help
Hiring	Clear job description, consistent interview questions, reference and background checks, a realistic preview of the job
Onboarding	Welcome, checklist of policies and routines, paperwork, shadowing time, a go-to person for questions
Support	Regular one-on-one check-ins, clear expectations, quick feedback, recognition
Growth	Paid training, credential support, goals, chances to take on new responsibilities
Leaving	Exit conversations to learn what could improve

Simple one-on-one check-in questions

- What's going well in your classroom?
- What's getting in your way?
- What support do you need from me?
- What would you like to learn next?

Remind providers that Virginia licensing sets requirements for staff qualifications, background checks, and training hours; the session builds on those requirements, not instead of them.

Implementation: your 30-day plan

Each provider leaves with one commitment and a 4-week plan; the Business Specialist checks progress at the next coaching session. Progress here also counts toward the pilot goal of at least one new or improved business practice per provider.

Week	Action	Done when
Week 1	Update one job description with duties, schedule, and pay range.	Job description is current
Week 2	Build or update an onboarding checklist.	Checklist is ready
Week 3	Hold a one-on-one check-in with each staff member (or set your own growth goal if home-based).	Check-ins are done
Week 4	Choose one retention practice to start, such as monthly recognition or paid training time.	Practice has started

Tie-in to coaching

At the next individual coaching session, the Business Specialist will:

- ☐ Review the job description and onboarding checklist
- ☐ Discuss what came up in staff check-ins
- ☐ Confirm the retention practice and how it will be paid for, if needed
- ☐ Note any business practice change in the provider's progress record

Commitment card

Have providers fill this in before they leave and keep a copy:

- The job description I will update: _____
- One thing I'll add to onboarding: _____
- My check-in schedule: _____
- My retention practice: _____

Key takeaways

Close the session by reading these aloud; they also appear on the Provider Handout.

1. **Hire with clarity.** A clear job description attracts the right people.
2. **Onboard on purpose.** A checklist helps new staff succeed quickly.
3. **Check in regularly.** Short one-on-ones catch problems early.
4. **Invest in growth.** Training and goals give staff a reason to stay.
5. **Learn from goodbyes.** Exit conversations show what to improve.

Activities and discussion

Activity: Build your onboarding checklist (15 minutes)

Starting from the sample, providers customize an onboarding checklist for their program: paperwork, licensing requirements, policies, daily routine, emergency procedures, and who to ask for help. Pairs swap and suggest one addition.

Discussion questions

- Where have you found your best staff?
- What do new staff struggle with most in their first month?
- How do you recognize staff for good work?
- What training has made the biggest difference for your team?

Peer Connections prompt (August)

"Training, benefits, and staff wellbeing." Providers share one training, benefit, or wellbeing practice that their staff appreciate, and one they'd like to try.

Handouts for this session

Walk through the **Workforce Practices Tips and Tricks** sheet during the content segment, and give out the **Workforce Practices Provider Handout** at the end.